

forest GUMP

✱ **Kallen Pokkudan, 71**

Project Conservation
of mangrove forests
in Kerala

Can-do Icons A.K.
Gopalan and B.R. Ambedkar

6,740 sq km

mangrove forests stretch
across India, of which 88



per cent is on the
east coast and
the Andaman
Nicobar islands



Not many remember his real name. Kallen Pokkudan is Kandal Pokkudan to most. Kandal in Malayalam means mangroves and for this poor Dalit agricultural labourer, it is an apt monicker. Having spent the past two decades preserving, planting and tirelessly campaigning for their protection, this school dropout is now considered the master of mangroves.

Environmentalists have only recently discovered the ecological significance of mangroves which are called the "rainforests of the fragile coastal ecosystem". But for Pokkudan and his Pulaya community, it was part of their traditional indigenous knowledge. "Kandal forests are essential to protect fish and other marine life at the mouth of the river. They also work as the coast's natural shield against flood, erosion, salinisation and even natural calamities like tsunami," says the short and stocky Pokkudan, 71, running a hand through his shoulder-length hair. "I took up conservation seriously in 1980s when a storm swept off children walking

back from school," says Pokkudan.

His village Ezhom, on the banks of Pazhayangadi river in Kannur district, has at 500 acres, the state's longest stretch of contiguous mangrove forests where he has planted more than 10,000 saplings. However, his passion has earned him enemies too, including his one-time comrade in the CPI(M) and villagers like K. Babu, shop keeper, who sees greater benefits in the road that came up after a failed attempt by Pokkudan to save the mangrove patch.

Now a pin-up boy for the greens, Pokkudan has even published his autobiography, *My Life Amongst Mangroves*. The crusader has also completed his second book. "Kerala had about 700 sq km of mangroves four decades ago, which has come down to 17 sq km now and will disappear soon unless authorities act fast." But anyone listening?

“

I was once called crazy. At times I too thought I was like a mad mangrove. Now people are more aware.

KALLEN POKKUDAN, Environmental activist

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by M.G. Radhakrishnan